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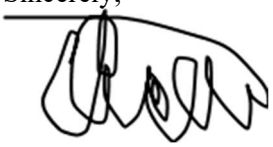
Dear DTA Committee Member,

On behalf of the English Department, I am very pleased to nominate Zackary Kiebach for the Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. Following the mandate of Paolo Freire, Zackary establishes a productive and empowering dialogue with their students. Before the term begins, Zackary solicits student feedback, asking them to describe the teaching practices and learning and environments that best help them learn. After making some adjustments before the students even see the syllabus, Zackary again asks for their input at midterm. Zackary again practices sound teaching methods by discussing with students their suggestions for a mid-course adjustment. In their SET comments, many students praise Zackary for soliciting their ideas about the course, and one in particular captures the salutary effect of this act of trust: "[Zackary] took our midterm feedback to heart and implemented suggestions right away, which I think greatly heightened the experience of the class." Trust plays an important roll in student growth, especially in Zackary's classes in which he encourages students to write from and about their personal experiences. Zackary makes a special effort to enjoin students to gain the trust of their peers, and they trust Zackary's intentions as they do so. One student explains the emotional and intellectual boost of being vulnerable in writing: "This forced me to confront my fears and anxieties around sharing my personal writing with others and receiving feedback, and while I found it very nerve wracking, this experience was a great opportunity for me. Students have written heartfelt, vulnerable, extremely well–done poems in this class, and getting to read them...has been extremely inspiring to me. Learning how to deliver useful feedback has also been a great way for me to develop as a writer this quarter, and something that this course has given me extensive practice in." In the students' words we find evidence of the independent, mature, and creative thought and action inspired by Zackary's careful cultivation of a dialogue with and among students.

Zackary enjoins students to contribute to their learning by shaping the construction of the course, from materials to in-class exercises. Zackary emphasizes this point on the syllabus: "The syllabus is a living document, meant to give you an idea of what we may or may not choose to read, depending on the needs and interests of the class. (I will be sure to check in, and I am happy to adjust the amount of reading at any point.)." Perhaps the keywords to describe Zackary's pedagogy is responsiveness and flexibility.

Because Zackary has learned so much from their students about being a better teacher, and because Zackary has continued to study the best practices for promoting student success, they have earned the Distinguished Teaching Award.

Sincerely,



Christopher M. Mott
TA Coordinator

Self-Statement from the Nominee

I have taught for seven quarters at UCLA: three as a teaching assistant and four as the primary instructor for classes I developed. Before graduate school, I worked as an educator, but being a TA taught me the various idiosyncrasies of the university discussion section. I learned to teach material outside my comfort zone, give more directive grading feedback, and foster an environment open to unpolished comments and clarifying questions.

My work as a TA provided me with the tools to construct my own English 20W course, a creative writing workshop. Titled "Poetic Subterfuge," the course investigates genres of writing we often take for granted (lists, letters, journals, video games) as models for poetry. Writing a poem that is also a letter, for example, becomes a means of investigating the formal structures which govern any kind of epistolary correspondence: who the letter is directed towards, the association of intimacy we bring to them, the clinical redundancies of the corporate email. The poems the students write (and the corresponding reading packets) require them to think critically about these conventions, much as one might think critically about the metrical structure of an aubade or a villanelle.

My first attempt went well, though not without some hiccups. The students found the workshop's premise enticing. However, they gave strong feedback for adjustments. When a student gave a fully "incorrect" interpretation of a poem, I was often too cautious and did not correct this in class—I overly worried about shutting the student down. Additionally, I favored teaching texts that were generally experimental and opaque. In their feedback, students requested that more conventional poems be included in the syllabus, so they could better understand the forms these more "difficult" poems reacted against.

I taught the class two additional times, each with revisions to both the syllabus and my facilitation of discussion. I began orienting the students to the vast range of forms a poem might take in a reading packet titled "Seven Poems Concerning Flowers"—a kind of speedrun of the many forms a poem can take, experimental or not. We discussed the use of the rose (a trope of poetry that students are generally familiar with) in both Shakespeare's "Sonnet 54" and H.D.'s "Sea Rose," published three centuries later and about as far from a conventional sonnet as one can get.

I learned the importance of providing context and guiding questions, especially for more difficult work, and gradually expanded my lecture slides. I noted the various writing styles each class favored as I peppered my syllabus with new additions each quarter (Sylvia Plath, Hanif Abdurraquib, Ocean Vuong). I used midterm evaluations to adjust the balance between full-class and small-group discussion, eventually adding more time for students to peer-review their original work. Each class I taught, while under the same premise, was an entirely new experience.

Even as I have transitioned to teaching a critical reading and writing course, titled "Viral Cultures," I apply much of what I learned from teaching poetry workshops. "Viral Cultures" examines various modes of "virality" (from internet memes to pandemic narratives), stemming from questions I had been thinking through with my first peer-reviewed publication with *Post45*. While 4W courses are

meant to teach textual analysis, I found that having students engage creatively with the course material can be extremely formative in developing their voices as literary critics. Poets are, as I had seen in my workshop, the most astute readers of poetry.

There has been nothing more pleasurable for me as an instructor than, for example, reviewing short films made by students in the style of Chris Marker's *La Jetée* (a film composed of still images), and the ensuing discussion regarding how differently each student viewed the film after completing the assignment. Over the quarter, students have learned close reading by dissecting internet memes, created "LA Ghost" photo blogs in the style of the protagonist of Ling Ma's *Severance*, and, generally, developed as both literary critics and critical thinkers.

Malleability in a course must come from the instructor, not the student. My goal as an instructor is to give students the agency to take their learning into their own hands. I have learned how to step back, listen, revise, and revise again. I have found that creative and analytical work are deeply entwined, that by giving our students permission to experiment with the genres of writing we investigate, they are able to build the confidence and understanding to discuss them on a much deeper level.

Teaching Statement

Education, to me, is a kind of architecture. My role is less in building the class myself but offering a kind of blueprint, designing the basic structure for a physical space in which the students might supply their own furnishings. I might begin the quarter with measurements, floor plans, and a basic sense of user needs, yet the space is only fully realized in how the students *choose* to inhabit it, a delicate and mutable interior we design as a collective. I want students to feel agency in building the course themselves, learning from one another and taking their education into their own hands.

The work I teach is often difficult, as is any practice of intellectual labor. I think here of the various architectural edifices of Shusaku Arakawa and Madeline Gins. Like much experimental writing, their buildings are often acutely uncomfortable. The floors are uneven and often sloped. Our vision upon entering is assaulted with a panoply of color: the fire hydrant yellow of one wall clashing with slashes of orange, red, pink, and green. The large windows render these colors themselves as fluctuating points of perception. Much like an interpretation of a difficult poem or the organization of a syllabus, the interiority of the space is one that constantly changes. I often think of it as a model for my classroom: a fluid space of difficulty and playfulness, of collaboration and access.

I have several learning goals for the students who enter my classes. In helping provide students with the foundational skills of literary analysis, the hope is that they leave the class with the ability to apply these tools to artifacts that are not necessarily even literary. My aim is for them to be able to understand how form is relevant in political messaging or shapes the content they are fed through algorithms, to learn to think critically about what they encounter rather than passively accepting it. I want them to find community: to develop a coterie of fellow writers with whom they might share work after the course ends and, more basically, to build the necessary trust for emulating and learning from the work of their peers. I want them to find pleasure in work that is not seamless and digestible but rather invokes careful consideration and thought. In sum, I want them to develop not as critics, but as critical thinkers.

These factors remain at the front of my mind as I have designed (and redesigned) various blueprints for my English 20W course, one that focuses on their own generation of experimental poetry. The course asks students to reevaluate commonplace genres of writing that they are likely to encounter in their daily lives—from lists to letters to journals to video games—and consider reevaluating the often-unspoken formal structures of each through a basic question. What happens when we reconstitute this basic form of written communication as a poem?
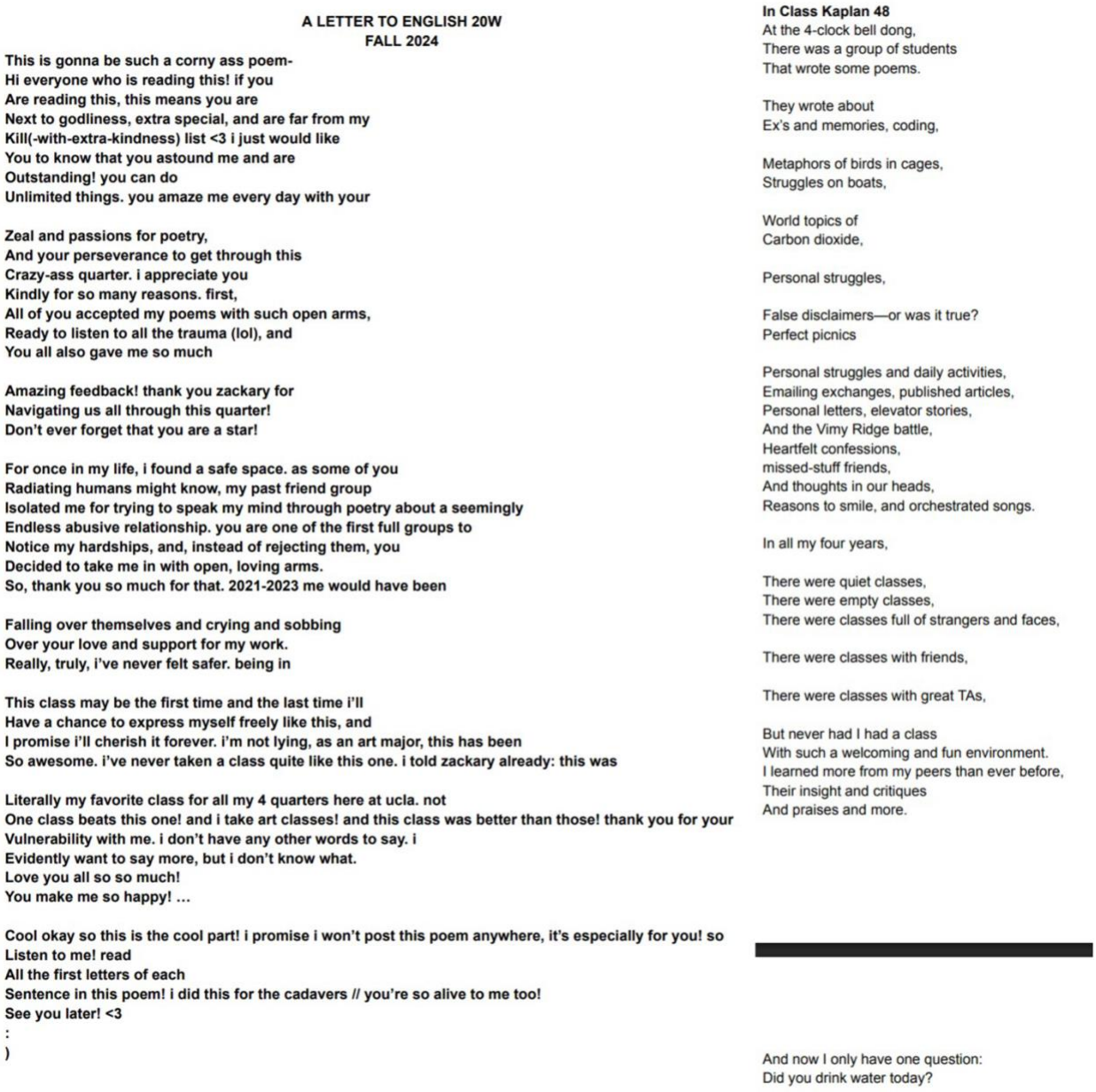
Each quarter, some students find themselves resistant to the assigned material. After reading Cody-Rose Clevidence's "Pollinate: By Hand," one of my students, Joshua, asks what the point is of writing that is so difficult to understand. Another student chimes in, wondering why they accept difficulty in visual art but, with writing, that difficulty feels more obtrusive. For the most part, I leave Joshua's question open: it is one they will continue to pose answers to as a collective over the duration of the course. Often, when students struggle with a work, I encourage them to engage with it more affectively. What is the role of the disorientation we experience? I ask them not to make

prescriptive readings but simply to find elements of the poems to "steal" for their own creative work: how might they adapt a difficult formal structure to their own voice?

I find that, by the middle of the quarter, students often feel liberated by the freedom to deviate from expected forms. Marie, who spoke little during our first meetings, presented a work of performance art during our first workshop: an envelope addressed to each student, which we were instructed to open and then tear the image-poem inside into two pieces. (This precipitated a memorable conversation on how each student's unique tear became part of the poem's identity as a visual artifact—did we viciously rip through the body of text on the page, or simply rip off a small piece?). Students began feeling enough ownership over their writing to integrate experience from their respective majors into their work. For Mia's workshop piece, she found inspiration in her background as a Music Performance major, handing out scripts to each student and conducting the class in an improvisatory and aleatoric performance (something between John Zorn and Kurt Schwitters). These are some of my most treasured moments as an educator: when students can apply the tools of the course to their own unique passions, jettisoning any preconceived boundaries between *this* discipline and *that*.

I want students to have the confidence to continue their work as writers, find a daily writing practice outside of the class that best suits their lives. I come back to the very first question I begin the course with each quarter: "What does poetry *do*?" For many, it is a form of journaling, an emotional refuge within the fast-paced life of the university. For others, it's a political tool, a means of circulating politics and care. For some, it's simply an adornment, a beautiful object upon which to gaze. I do not find any of these interpretations more right or wrong than others, but, beneath the question, I am asking what poetry can do for them specifically. Some might go on to publish, while others might simply continue writing small, private poems in their Notes apps in order to process their daily lives. I want students to define their own relationship to writing. Above all, I want them to continue doing it in the manner that best serves them.

ARTIFACT ONE: CLASSROOM COMMUNITY



A LETTER TO ENGLISH 20W
FALL 2024

This is gonna be such a corny ass poem-
Hi everyone who is reading this! if you
Are reading this, this means you are
Next to godliness, extra special, and are far from my
Kill(-with-extra-kindness) list <3 i just would like
You to know that you astound me and are
Outstanding! you can do
Unlimited things. you amaze me every day with your

Zeal and passions for poetry,
And your perseverance to get through this
Crazy-ass quarter. i appreciate you
Kindly for so many reasons. first,
All of you accepted my poems with such open arms,
Ready to listen to all the trauma (lol), and
You all also gave me so much

Amazing feedback! thank you zackary for
Navigating us all through this quarter!
Don't ever forget that you are a star!

For once in my life, i found a safe space. as some of you
Radiating humans might know, my past friend group
Isolated me for trying to speak my mind through poetry about a seemingly
Endless abusive relationship. you are one of the first full groups to
Notice my hardships, and, instead of rejecting them, you
Decided to take me in with open, loving arms.
So, thank you so much for that. 2021-2023 me would have been

Falling over themselves and crying and sobbing
Over your love and support for my work.
Really, truly, i've never felt safer. being in

This class may be the first time and the last time i'll
Have a chance to express myself freely like this, and
I promise i'll cherish it forever. i'm not lying, as an art major, this has been
So awesome. i've never taken a class quite like this one. i told zackary already: this was

Literally my favorite class for all my 4 quarters here at ucla. not
One class beats this one! and i take art classes! and this class was better than those! thank you for your
Vulnerability with me. i don't have any other words to say. i
Evidently want to say more, but i don't know what.
Love you all so so much!
You make me so happy! …

Cool okay so this is the cool part! i promise i won't post this poem anywhere, it's especially for you! so
Listen to me! read
All the first letters of each
Sentence in this poem! i did this for the cadavers // you're so alive to me too!
See you later! <3
:
)

In Class Kaplan 48
At the 4-clock bell dong,
There was a group of students
That wrote some poems.

They wrote about
Ex's and memories, coding,

Metaphors of birds in cages,
Struggles on boats,

World topics of
Carbon dioxide,

Personal struggles,

False disclaimers—or was it true?
Perfect picnics

Personal struggles and daily activities,
Emailing exchanges, published articles,
Personal letters, elevator stories,
And the Vimy Ridge battle,
Heartfelt confessions,
missed-stuff friends,
And thoughts in our heads,
Reasons to smile, and orchestrated songs.

In all my four years,

There were quiet classes,
There were empty classes,
There were classes full of strangers and faces,

There were classes with friends,

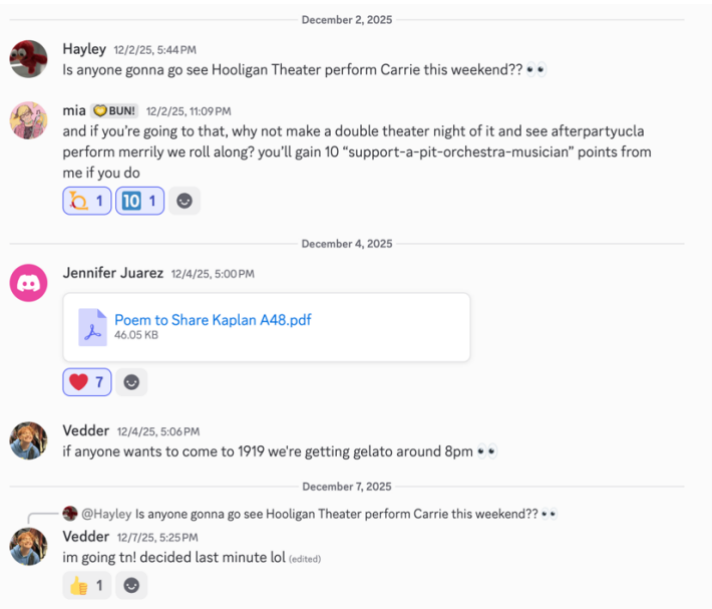
There were classes with great TAs,

But never had I had a class
With such a welcoming and fun environment.
I learned more from my peers than ever before,
Their insight and critiques
And praises and more.

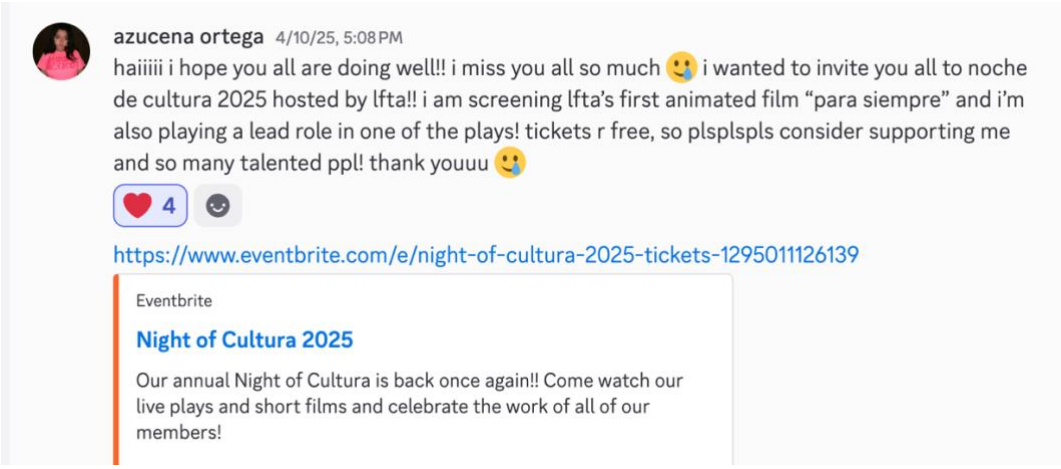
[redacted]

And now I only have one question:
Did you drink water today?

Attached above are two thank-you poems written by students (not submitted assignments or solicited by me), which they shared during the poetry reading we hold at the end of each quarter. "A Letter to English 20W" (an acrostic poem) was written by Azucena Ortega during the Fall 2024 version of the class, and "In Class Kaplan 48" was written by Jennifer Juarez in the Fall 2025 iteration. I am including them because they are among the most meaningful (and emotional!) moments I've had as an instructor. Azucena was not an enthusiastic student when the class started (she would occasionally put her head down and nap during class the first two weeks), but came to be one of the most vocal participants in class discussions as the course progressed. Jennifer was extremely shy at the start of the course, and her sharing how important the community we built over the quarter was to her was an enormously formative moment for me as an instructor. The poem she included references all the poems submitted by other students who were workshopped throughout the quarter.

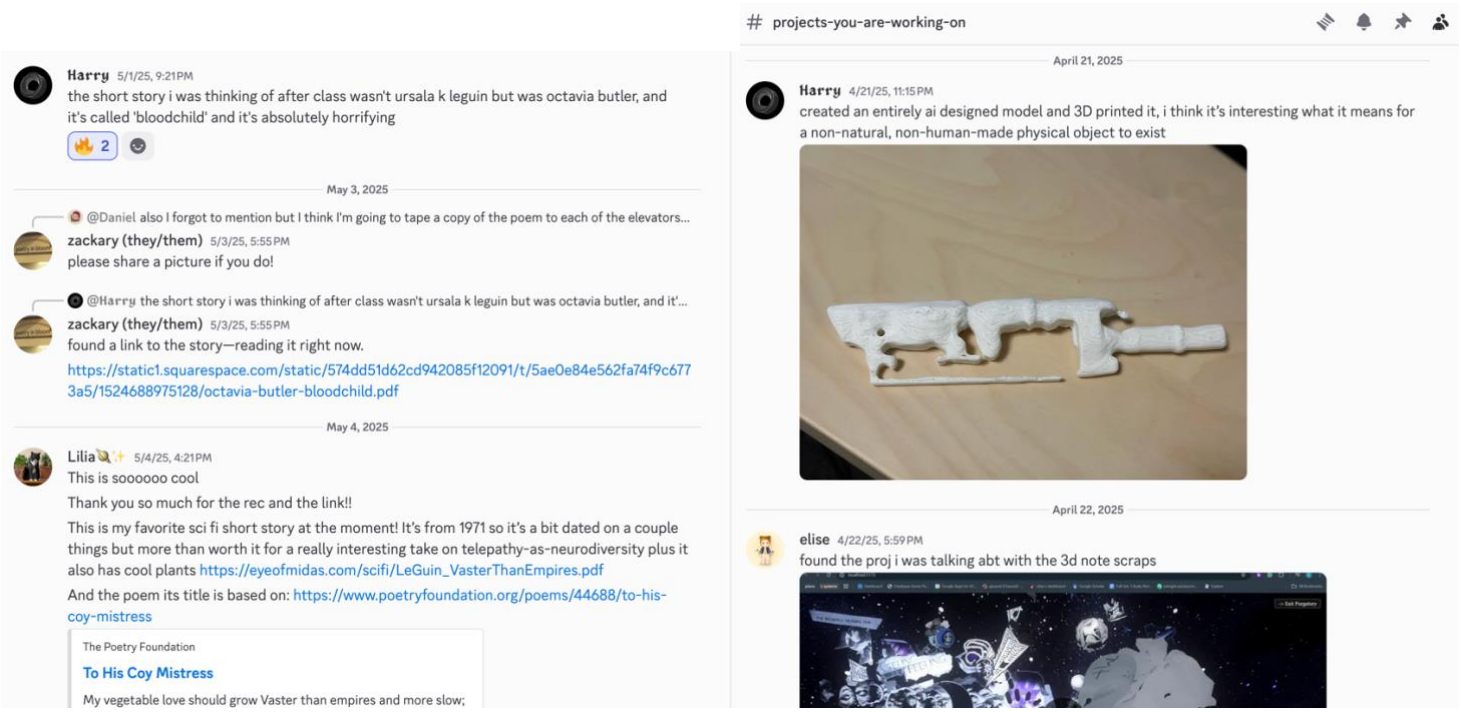






Attached are some examples of students finding community outside the classroom—the upper-left screenshot shows Discord chatter from Fall 2025, and the upper-right screenshot includes pictures the class wanted to take at the end of the quarter in Fall 2024. (Hayley and Vedder did, in fact, end up attending the *Carrie* performance together.) After taking the pictures on the right-hand side, the class started a group text to stay in touch after the course ended. As an aside, Abdhi's comment is in reference to Elliot, a music major, who opted to share a wonderful musical composition during the final reading.

I'm also including this third image as an example to show how Discord has been used after the class has ended—students sharing updates and achievements, inviting one another to events. It is important to me as an instructor that they can still use the community we built over the quarter once that quarter has ended, so I keep the class Discord pages active after the class has officially ended and encourage students to continue using them (should they desire).



I found these two images generally illustrative of why I chose Discord as my primary online communication tool during my classes. The left (stems from the #reading-recommendations channel, in which students are encouraged to share work they are engaging with outside of the class. Here, it is used to continue the discussion after class, as Harry had been reminded of an Octavia Butler story based on the premise of one of Lillia's poems. (The conversation continues, but I opted to keep the screenshot short for space.) The students can use Discord as a space to engage with course material less formally and share material that is formative for them.

The right image, from #projects-you-are-working-one, gives students space to share work they generate outside of the class. Both Harry's and Elise's posts arose from conversations about their workshop poems, which drew on influences from their respective majors.

ARTIFACT TWO: STUDENT FEEDBACK (SET SURVEYS)

Honestly, Zackary is one of the best instructors I have ever had being at UCLA. Zack is sweet, understanding, patient, kind, silly, all the best qualities. I wouldn't say that Zack has any weaknesses because I never struggled in this course. The workload is manageable, Zack has good communication skills and class was very engaging, which I loved. Despite it being two hours long, Zack still made the class very fun and I genuinely enjoyed showing up every lecture. I wish I could take Zack for another course because I genuinely love their teaching style and their class as a whole. Overall, I would never stop recommending Zack as an instructor.

I absolutely loved this course! The instructor provided thoughtful and helpful comments when workshopping works of writing and fostered a welcoming environment for students. The structure for the class was also perfect, combining both group work and class discussion. There are no weaknesses in this course, I would recommend this course with Zackary to any student who is interested in creative writing.

Zackary is an excellent instructor who shows deep care and attention to their students. As someone who tends to stay quiet in class, they created an environment where I felt empowered to share my ideas. Not only did I feel comfortable doing so, but I also felt like my insights were taken seriously. This class provided a space that was so different from any other class I've taken at UCLA. I truly feel that anyone who takes this course will find deep value in Zackary's teaching style and approach.

Even on my rough days I looked forward to coming to class because I knew I would learn something new. And Zackary was really good at making course material and just creative writing in general a very fun and engaging, thoughtful and collaborative process. And I appreciated their ability to make the class feel like a nice creative community. Zackary was very understanding and communicative throughout the course which overall made it an enjoyable and interesting course for me.

Zachary created such an open, welcoming space for us to share our poetry and learn about the art form. Sharing such personal writing in a class setting is very vulnerable, and Zachary always did everything in their ability to make sure everyone in the class not only was comfortable sharing their work, but had built connections to their classmates which allowed for respectful and productive discussions and peer feedback. The main adjustment I would make to the class, although I understand that the time allotted for our sections makes this difficult to achieve, would be to incorporate more opportunities for feedback throughout the quarter, whereas currently each student only gets comprehensive feedback on their work once or twice throughout the class. Otherwise, this class was an incredible experience and introduced me to so many new poets and forms of poetry. I know I will walk away from this class a much better writer than when I walked into it, and I am grateful I for the opportunity it provided me not only to improve my poetry, but to connect with so many others my age with the same love for writing.

Zackary made this class one of my favorite classes during my time here at UCLA and the class that probably got me through Spring quarter. Taking creative writing as a Pre–Med, I came into the class a little nervous about my own abilities when it came to writing and examining poetry, but Zackary made the class feel like such a safe space to venture off into the world of creative writing! The smaller style of the enrollment made interacting with both them as the professor and with fellow students so much more meaningful and impactful, and I was always so excited coming to this class to hear and discuss the viewpoints and critiques of other and our own poetry, all which wouldn't have been possible with Zackary, who always engaged so deeply with our discussion posts and brought them into the conversations we had in class. This kind of attention made me feel seen in a way that I haven't experienced in any other course, at UCLA or beyond. Their dedication to the class, the material, and to us made it such an inviting space of learning, healing, and honest expression. One thing I noticed was how Zackary rarely shut down or denied interpretations we had about each poem, they always made space for the multiple readings and really emphasized how poetry comes alive through this interaction between text and reader!

Attached above is feedback from my Spring 2025 English 20W course. I thought it would be useful to give a sense of what the overall feedback might look like for class, rather than only excerpted sections (which I'll attach below with notes). I was delighted by the last comment, in which the student expressed nervousness about taking a creative writing course as a Pre-Med student, yet felt the environment was safe enough for them to attempt something outside their comfort zone.

I also learned much from the recommendation to incorporate more opportunities for feedback throughout the quarter (the fifth comment), which became a major revision in my next iteration of the course. Instead of just having a longer, full-class discussion of each student's work once per quarter (each Thursday), I set aside time each Tuesday for small-group peer review to discuss and workshop the poems they generated that week. I saw the success of this approach in the final portfolios submitted at the end of the quarter—the students reflected not only in the written feedback I had given them but also in the specific comments made by their peers in small groups. It was a great suggestion.

- I really enjoyed this class so much. As reflected in my course characteristics, when I first took the class, I was at first a little hesitant seeing that it was poetry, which is one of my weakest areas. I always felt like poetry was something that I could never understand. Whenever I would read poems, I would feel like the author would be speaking over my head, and I just wouldn't be able to understand any of it. However, as I went through this class and read the poetry readings every week, I found myself falling in love with poetry, which is something that I never would have expected when I first started. Now, I feel so much more confident and better equipped to read and analyze poetry than I did in September. All the class readings were perfect, and I really liked how Professor Kiebach picked from such a diverse range of authors from different ethnicities. Reading Asian American authors, such as Ocean Vuong, who reflected on the Vietnam War was really empowering to read. I also really liked how welcoming this class was. As a freshman it was really nice to have a community of writers to return to. Perhaps most personally, I really appreciated how helpful Professor Kiebach has been. They have always been willing to answer any questions I have and would always provide so much help during office hours. I loved this class so much because I can really see how much I have grown in just 10 weeks. If I reread the very first poem I wrote for the first week and the poems I am able to write now, there has been so much improvement, and it is only through this class that I was able to improve. Of course, I recognize there is so much more room for me to grow and learn, but this class has allowed me to grow so much as a writer and English major. I am so much more excited about poetry, and grateful for taking this class because I am now able to appreciate something so beautiful.

I appreciate here, in particular, the note that the student felt empowered by seeing writers who reflected their own experiences, as well as the general shift from poetry as something "I could never understand" to a genre of writing the student fell in love with.

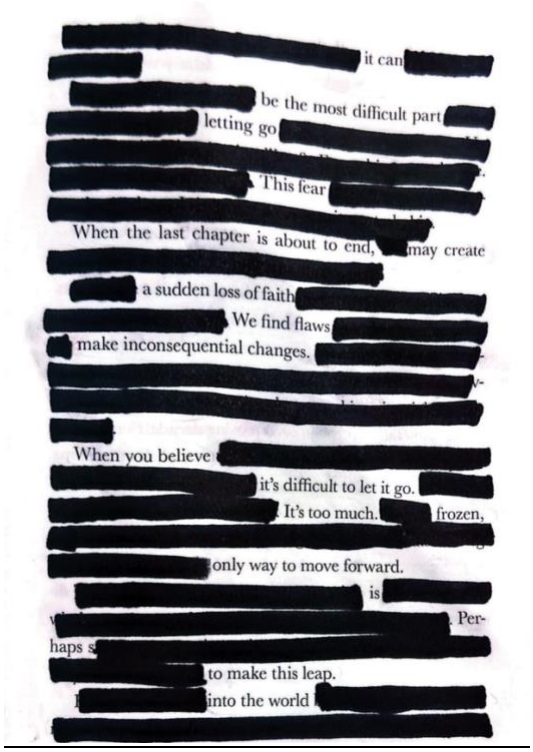
- Zackary is a very caring and thorough instructor who fosters really amazing conversation in our class. I have become significantly more confident in my skills in poetry–writing, and I have also grown closer with my classmates, forming relationships that I hope to carry with me after completing this class. Having the chance to share our work and provide/receive constructive criticism has not only allowed me to grow, but this class has felt like such a safe space since my first day, which is a really special feature of a poetry workshop, especially one containing many people who consider themselves beginners. Zackary has made space for us to do introductions with short updates on our week at the start of every class, allowing the space to feel more personal and comfortable and making sure that each student feels seen. The way they have structured the course is organized and fun, with interesting readings that we get to talk over organically as a class every Monday. These conversations are always very enriching, and I feel very welcome to share my thoughts without judgement. On Tuesdays, we submit our poems for the prescribed weekly prompt, and on Wednesdays we each leave a response on another student's poem, allowing us to put our writing out there in a lower stakes context. Additionally, students have their work more deeply dissected on their workshop dates. This forced me to confront my fears and anxieties around sharing my personal writing with others and receiving feedback, and while I found it very nerve wracking, this experience was a great opportunity for me, especially as an English major who wants a future in writing. Students have written heartfelt, vulnerable, extremely well–done poems in this class, and getting to read them every Thursday during student workshops has been extremely inspiring to me. Learning how to deliver useful feedback has also been a great way for me to develop as a writer this quarter, and something that this course has given me extensive practice in. Zackary facilitates workshop days in a very kind, non–judgmental way, guiding the conversation when needed and providing their own insightful feedback as well. Additionally, Zackary conducted a mid–quarter survey in which we could share our feedback on the class' structure, and it is clear that they really care about the experience of the students. I also valued the way that Zackary taught this course as a queer person, as trans perspectives were seen often in our readings, and being able to have conversations around these works was interesting and relevant to today. Overall, I feel so lucky that I was able to take this class this quarter, and I really hope that my friends will be able to take this class with Zackary in the future because it was such an amazing course, especially as one of my first ones.

The mid-quarter survey the student mentions is essential to my class, providing students with an opportunity to adjust the course structure to their needs.

- This course was one of the most enjoyable courses I've had so far at UCLA, both in content and in the level of engagement. Readings outside of the classroom were interesting and complex in an enjoyable way, and though I could not understand exactly what each reading meant, the practice of reading through each one and writing down entries with my own thoughts/comments/perspectives was valuable because it forced me to identify what exactly the text was getting at. I think one very strong component of the course is the discussions hosted in class, led by the TA. Not only is it a supportive and encouraging place where people are able to reflect on each other's interpretations, but it also aided my comprehension of the readings, and I left each class with a wider understanding of each piece. Being a creative writing course, there were also writing workshops that allowed for in depth focus on each other's writing, and the way the class was split (3 students per week) worked well with the class pacing. Later in the course, the instructor introduced more small group workshops, and these functioned well with the structure of the class to give students more feedback on pieces they wanted more attention on. I think the overall structure the class was set up in maximized my interest and engagement with the course material, and I really do feel like I'm leaving with a greater appreciation and eye for poetry in the different forms it can take. There isn't one specific prompt or week I was drawn in by, but each one was uniquely interesting in its own way. I don't really have suggestions for how to adjust the class because I see it as a very well paced and rewarding class with the way it is currently set up.

From my most recent course, after implementing the feedback on building in more time for small group workshops (from the previous quarter—see the comment on the previous page).

ARTIFACT THREE: STUDENT WORK



it can

be the most difficult part

letting go

This fear

When the last chapter is about to end, may create

a sudden loss of faith

We find flaws

make inconsequential changes.

When you believe

it's difficult to let it go.

It's too much. frozen,

only way to move forward.

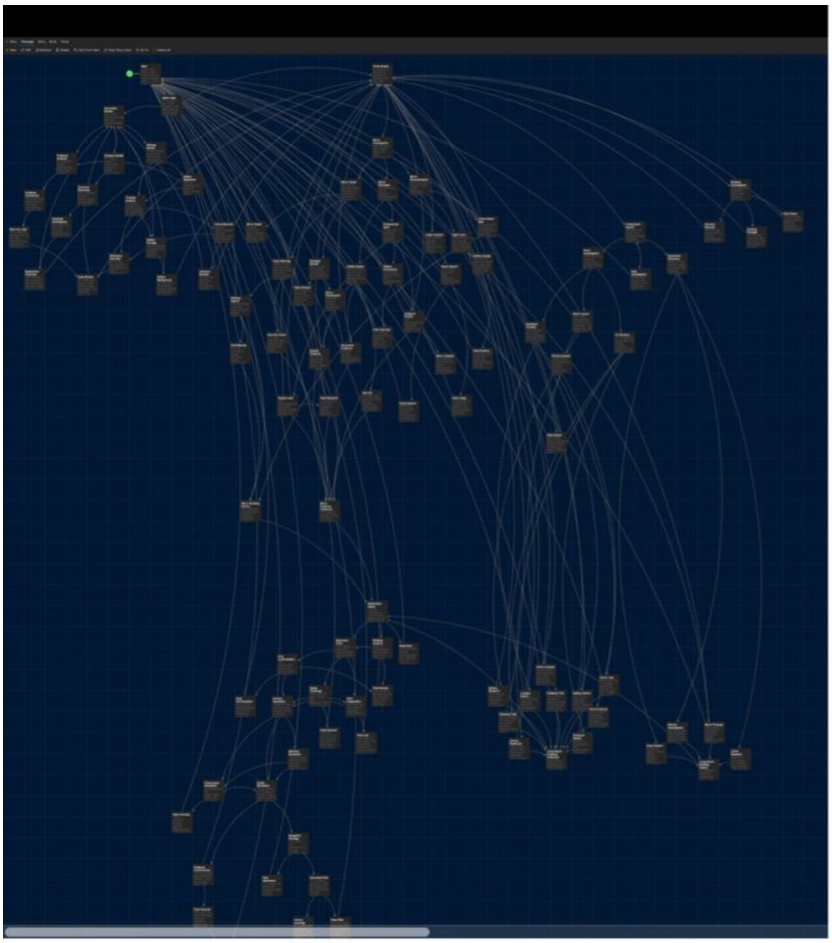
is

Per-

haps

to make this leap.

into the world



Your eyes flutter open, consciousness slowly seeping back.

You grab a notepad and start mapping out Martinez's last day:

- 9:00 AM - Arrives at museum for work (Security badge log)
- 2:00 PM - Meeting with gallery owner Marcus Wellington Sr. (Calendar entry)
- 2:15 PM - Leaves museum early (Badge log, unusual for her)
- 3:00 PM - Seen entering Saint's Crown Gallery (Security footage)
- 5:45 PM - Arrives home (Apartment security footage)
- 6:00 PM - Wellington claims she was still at gallery (Witness statement)
- 9:00 PM to Midnight - Estimated time of death (Autopsy report)

Something doesn't add up. You circle the contradicting times. Wellington's statement puts her at the gallery when security footage clearly shows her at home. Why would he lie about such an easily disprovable detail?

Pull Wellington's initial interview
Check gallery security footage
Review Martinez's phone records

The room's arrangement strikes you as deliberate - too deliberate. The coffee table sits precisely centered, like a museum display case. Gallery magazines radiate outward in a pattern that feels... familiar.

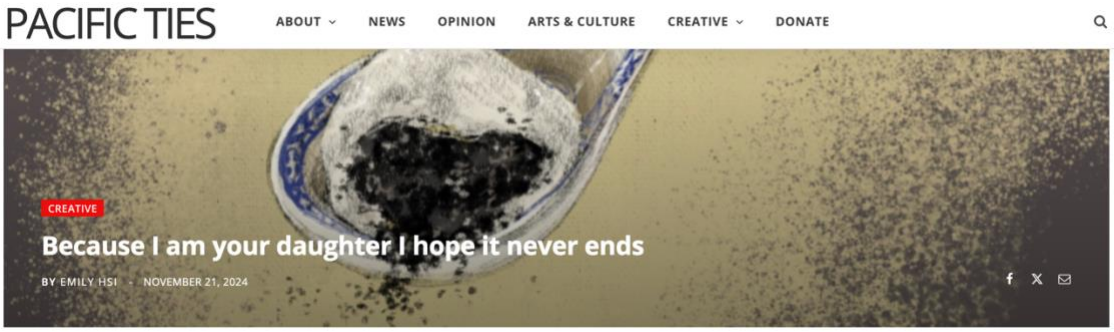
Without understanding the day's sequence of events, you miss the warning signs in the room's layout.

GAME OVER
You have died.

Try Again

On the previous page, I'm attaching two assignments submitted by the same student, Raju Wolfe. The first image (the scanned page with blacked-out text) is the first poem Raju submitted for the course during Week Two. The poem fits the basic learning goals of the first week—encouraging students to experiment with a less conventional approach to what a poem might look like—yet is not an outstanding submission. (Raju gives no context regarding what led him to choose this particular page, and the blackout poem generally takes much less intentional work on the part of the student.)

Raju, a Design & Media Arts major, flourished when he applied tools from his major to our course materials. The second set of images is the hypertext game he created at the end of the quarter. We had spoken during office hours about his ambition to work as a game developer upon graduating, and I encouraged him to use the final portfolio to write a narrative game in Twine (the software students used for the last assignment). As an instructor, I see it as important to watch students apply skills from their respective majors to their assignments. Raju submitted a postmodern murder mystery about an art gallery that showed enormous care, much more so than some of his earlier assignments, and it has become a work I have taught to students as a highly ambitious example of what they might create with Twine in later iterations of the class. (The screenshot on the left shows each of the many connecting paths the player might take through the game—some with dead ends that require them to begin the game again.)



I once thought that the whole earth could
fit under your damp eyelashes. And I
guess I was wrong, because when I was
pulling black braided rope through the
well of the village town, the sky stretched
itself out into the shape of a rice field. I
stood at one end, you on the opposite
side, and we waved to each other over a
rippling sea of green. Then July grew out
its long nails, dulled its blades in wet oil,
and returned to us in the careful shape of
love.

Above is another work by Emily Hsi, who published one of the poems we had been workshopping over the quarter in *Pacific Ties* (an enormous accomplishment!). We had met multiple times during office hours to discuss the steps for submitting poems for publication, which I cover during the quarter with the full class. I was delighted to see her work recognized here.

ARTIFACT FOUR: SYLLABI

Introduction to Creative Writing: Poetic Subterfuge
ENGL 20W LEC 3
4:00 PM — 5:50 PM Tuesdays and Thursdays
Kaplan Hall A48

Instructor: Zackary Kiebach (they/them)
Email: zackarykiebach@g.ucla.edu
Office Hours: Wednesday from 11:00am to 1:00 on Zoom. Sign up through YouCanBookMe.

During our course, we will be reading and taking inspiration from poems that are disguised: under the sign of other, more popular, genres, what can a poem truly *do*? We will write poems under the guise of lists, letters, plagiarized documents, journals, manifestos, images, and even video games. The work we generate will, hopefully, enable consideration of what exactly constitutes a poem. Does a poem require line breaks, or just an attention to sound, constructed the way one might compose a piece of music? Or can a poem also be an image, an object upon which we gaze rather than a text we read from left to right? Our poems will, at their core, be a form of literary subterfuge, one that moves away from common assumptions regarding what a poem can and cannot be.

The course is, at its core, a workshop. We will respectfully read and offer feedback on each other's creative work. The priority will be using our discussion of various poems as a means for generating ideas regarding how you might implement new, and sometimes unorthodox, structures into your own writing practice.

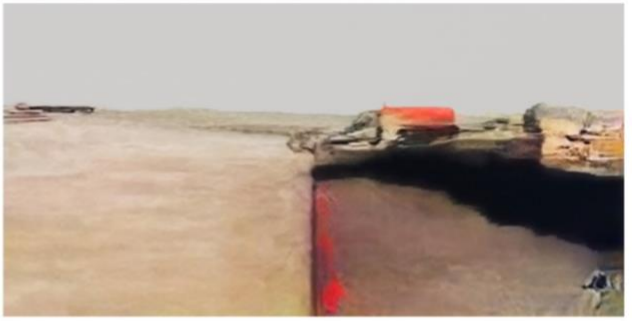
Class Procedure:

This is an intensive and generative workshop course supplemented by instructor-led and student-directed discussion. Our class will be divided into discussions of assigned readings each Tuesday and writing workshops on Thursdays. On Tuesdays, I will offer an overview of the texts we work through, with attention to the critical context from which each text developed, but for the most part my role will be to facilitate the development of student-generated ideas in the form of a dynamic roundtable discussion. The discussion posts will be essential: consider them a way to collect your thoughts on the text and ensure you have at least one contribution you are able to make during class. You should respond to the poem with both an analytical and critical eye: not only what the poem is trying to articulate, but *how* it is articulating it, the same way you might offer critique of a poem written by a peer.

Each Thursday, we will dedicate class to workshopping the work of two students. You will come prepared with questions about the work: questions on specific choices made by the poet, pitches for how an aspect of the poem might be adjusted or changed to reach its intended effect, or commentary on what is working in the poem and what is not. When time permits, we will break into small groups to discuss and offer feedback on all the poems we generated that week.

VIRAL CULTURES
English 4W—Winter 2026 Syllabus
2:00 PM—3:50 PM Tuesdays & Thursdays
Rolfe 3116

Class Location: Rolfe 3116
Instructor: Zackary Kiebach (they/them)
Office Hours: By appointment via Zoom
Meeting Time: Tues/Thurs 2:00-3:50 PM
Email: zackarykiebach@g.ucla.edu



Trevor Paglen, Highway of Death (Corpus: The Aftermath of the First Smart War) Adversarially Evolved Hallucination, 2017, dye sublimation metal print.

The term viral is as permeable as the bodies it infects. When we think of virality, we often first consider various modes of digital circulation—cults of celebrity, the recalcitrant earworms that accompany TikTok videos, the steady remixing of a niche meme, the recent surge of deepfakes and AI slop that have proliferated across the internet. The viral, here, can be defined through both its circulation and its transmissibility across digital platforms. But what new connotations around digital virality emerge when we contend with the biological origins of the metaphor—the infection, the virus, the epidemic? How is digital capitalism itself an agent of a more insidious virality, an attempt to infiltrate and colonize our attention much like a virus infects a host?

This quarter, we will examine the aesthetic and formal logic of the viral across bodies, minds, and machines. We will investigate how political ideology is circulated across memes, survey speculative histories of contagion (from post-apocalyptic corporate zombies to genetically-engineered gender warfare), track the narrative histories of illness and disability throughout literature and film. In our course, we will not contend with the digital and biological variants of virality as mutually exclusive, but rather necessary interlocutors in a larger conversation around circulation and contagion. The course requires short weekly critical experiments in an open format, as well as a final project, which may be critical or creative in form, developed in conversation with the instructor.

Within the English department, students can develop their own classes through the 20W and 4W series, both of which can be completed to satisfy the Writing II credit. The course on the left (titled "Poetic Subterfuge) is the most recent iteration of the 20W course I have now taught three times. Students write poems "disguised" as lists, letters, journals, manifestos, images, and video games in addition to learning the basics of close literary analysis.

The course on the right, titled Viral Cultures, is a 4W course with a more traditional emphasis on academic writing. The premise of the course stems from research I completed for a peer-reviewed article I published with *Post45*, titled "Glitch Ability: A Crip Poetics of Failure," although it attempts to render the joint disciplines of new media and disability studies more accessible for intro-level students.

AFTIFACT FIVE: ASSIGNMENTS

Meme Autoethnography (DUE WEDNESDAY, 1/07 BY 11:59PM): Please find a meme on the internet (this could be as niche or as widespread as you like) and write 2-3 paragraph analysis. You should answer the following questions.

(a) Where does this meme originate from? Is it part of a specific internet community? How would you describe how this meme is generally used? And how did you personally come across it? Try to articulate any specific visual elements that stand out to you (where the text is placed, how the image is used to generate humor, the visual fidelity of the image, etc.).

(b) Next, examine if there are any connections between the meme you have chosen and the Hito Steyerl or the Aria Taylor readings. Is this meme an example of a "poor" image (as articulated by either critic)? Does the meme imply anything about race, gender, sexuality, or disability? If the meme is low-resolution, what is the function of this rendering? What can the meme tell you about the subculture in which it is generally circulated (university groups, specific internet forums, etc.)?

CRITICAL WRITING EXPERIMENT 2 (DUE WEDNESDAY, 1/14 BY 11:59 P.M.): Create a (very) short film out of images in the style of Chris Marker. (These can simply be posted as a sequence of images to the Discord.) These could be as simple as trying to capture a small motion or gesture through image (a ball rolling across the floor, a friend mid-conversation, the view out of the window of a moving vehicle). It could be capturing something static from different angles (different perspectives of an object, a slow zoom, an aerial view). It might be a collection of discrete screenshots on a web browser used to create a narrative of some sort, or a sequence of doodles—the way you interpret prompt is up to you.

There is no limit to the number of images here, but I would recommend keeping it shorter! (Maybe five to six images would be a good number to aim for, but more or less is also fine.)

Next, write a one-paragraph reflection on the process. Be sure to include some reflection on the Susan Sontag reading.

Some questions you might consider in both the making of the film and the reflection (you do not need to answer all of these—think of them as simply potential points of consideration):

- To what extent is this a sequence of images? To what an extend is this a film? What is the difference anyways?
- What choices are you making in how much space you leave between each shot? (Are you trying to give the illusion of continuous motion by using many images to capture one movement, or leaving the motion sparser?)
- Why did you choose this particular subject for the film? What made it an interesting point of investigation for this particular prompt?
- How might you describe the narrative of the film? (If there is a narrative—there certainly does not have to be.)
- How might your film connect to Susan Sontag's argument around photography?

These are some samples of assignments from my more recent 4W course, titled "Viral Cultures." While some weeks emphasize more traditional academic writing styles, many ask students to complete "Critical Writing Experiments" in place of a traditional discussion post. The goal with these prompts is to have students engage not only as literary critics but also as active participants in the various genres of work we read over the quarter. One of the most formative lessons I took from the Introduction to Creative Writing course I taught before this was the extent to which generating original creative work can be a vital tool in helping students develop their voices as critics, prompting modes of reflection on the various texts we study that would not be possible with a traditional discussion post.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES UCLA
BERKELEY · DAVIS · IRVINE · LOS ANGELES · MERCED · RIVERSIDE · SAN DIEGO · SAN FRANCISCO SANTA BARBARA · SANTA CRUZ

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH
KAPLAN HALL
BOX 951530
LOS ANGELES, CA 90095-1530
(310) 825-4173

February 13, 2026

Dear Award Committee Members:

I am writing this letter in wholehearted support of Zachary Kiebach's application to be considered for the Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. Zackary is one of the best TAs I have worked with at UCLA. I met Zackary when they were a second-year graduate student and had been assigned to be a TA for my large GE class. They took on the responsibility of the role with a remarkable level of commitment and they served as a crucial interlocutor and collaborator throughout the course. Since then, I have mentored Zackary and am the co-chair of their dissertation.

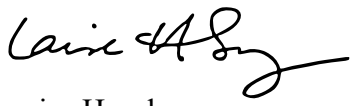
I observed Zackary's teaching when they were my TA. They were an open, generous and, confident presence at the front of the classroom. That day, Zackary was running a thesis writing workshop with the students for papers on the use of color in film. First, Zackary reviewed the thesis of my lecture that week on color theory, revealing to students how the argument was drawn from the film by outlining the lecture in reverse. Zackary then had students workshop their own thesis about the color red. By working through a series of readings of specific scenes from the film, the class collectively constructed a thesis about red's fungibility and volatility in the film, proposing that it functioned as a marker of transition rather than a signature of an object. It was an enormous feat on Zackary's part to bring the students to a place where they were able to come up with this sophisticated argument themselves.

Zackary is a careful orchestrator in their classroom, attending both to the task at hand and to the needs of the students, evident in the critical and creative writing courses of their own they have devised. Zackary is a highly skilled writer and has honed their own critical voice in their prose. They know just how hard it is to write well and how much practice this takes, and they are able to model that practice for their students. It is enormously exciting to imagine where they will use their voice in the classroom and in their scholarly and creative work.

Zackary has made significant progress on their dissertation, which is an important intervention in the fields of digital humanities, disability studies, and contemporary poetics. Having the time now to focus on their work will enable Zackary to complete a significant portion of the

manuscript and continue to publish in their fields. Zackary has been a joy to teach and to mentor throughout their time in the program, which is particularly significant for this award. They are highly attuned to what it means to be a student. They bring this awareness not only to their scholarship but also to their pedagogical practice, which is focused so clearly on how to give undergraduates the best possible education by helping them be the best possible students. I cannot think of a more worthy recipient for this award.

Sincerely,



Louise Hornby
Associate Professor and Vice-Chair for Undergraduate Studies